

German Adverb Suffixes & Prefixes

Complete reference guide to German adverb formation: Derivational suffixes (-weise, -s, -wärts, -ens, -maßen, -halber...), pronominal compounding prefixes (da(r)-, wo(r)-, hier-...), and directional particle affixes.

How Adverbs are Formed in German:

- Unlike English (which almost always adds -ly), German adverbs are formed through several distinct morphological processes:
- Adverbial Genitive (-s):** Added to times/days to create habits (*morgens* = every morning, *abends*, *sonntags*).
 - Manner & Perspective (-weise):** Converts adjectives/nouns into viewpoint adverbs (*glücklicherweise* = fortunately, *teilweise* = partially).
 - Directional Alignment (-wärts):** Denotes vector of movement (*vorwärts* = forward, *heimwärts* = homeward).

Pronominal Adverbs (Da- & Wo- Compounds):

- Instead of saying preposition + pronoun for inanimate objects, German fuses **da(r)-** or **wo(r)-** with the preposition:
- über *das* → **darüber** (about that) | *worüber?* (about what?)
 - mit *dem* → **damit** (with that) | *womit?* (with what?)
 - auf *das* → **darauf** (on that) | *worauf?* (on what?)
 - Insert '-r-' if preposition starts with a vowel (*daran*, *worin*).

1. Primary Adverb Derivation Suffixes (Adverbsuffixe)

Suffix	Semantic Function & Derivation	High-Frequency Examples & Meaning
-weise	1. Manner / Mode ('in X way') 2. Sentence-level speaker viewpoint / attitude	glücklicherweise (fortunately), normalerweise (normally), teilweise (partially), beispielsweise (for example), möglicherweise (possibly), schrittweise (step by step)
-s	Adverbial Genitive: Transforms time nouns into recurring regular habits / general states	morgens (in the mornings), abends (in the evenings), nachts (at night), montags (on Mondays), anfangs (initially), spätestens (at the latest), mindestens (at least)
-wärts	Directional vector, spatial heading, orientation (English -wards)	vorwärts (forward), rückwärts (backward), aufwärts (upward), abwärts (downward), heimwärts (homeward), seitwärts (sideways), stadtwärts (city-bound)
-ens	Ordinals and sequencing in discourse / general estimation	erstens (firstly), zweitens (secondly), drittens (thirdly), übrigens (by the way), meistens (mostly), bestens (in the best way)
-maßen	Measure, degree, extent, proportionality	einigermaßen (to some extent / fairly), gleichermaßen (equally / likewise), gewissermaßen (in a certain manner), bekanntermaßen (as is well known)
-halber	For the sake of, on account of (governs or attaches to genitive noun stems)	der Ordnung halber (for the sake of order), sicherheitshalber (for safety's sake), ehrenhalber (honorary / for honor), vollständigkeitshalber (for completeness)
-dings	Circumstance, reality confirmation (colloquial / lexicalized)	allerdings (however / indeed), neuerdings (recently / lately), schlechterdings (simply / utterly)
-weg	Continuous completeness, flat generalization without exception	durchweg (consistently / throughout), schlichtweg (plainly / simply), geradewegs (straight / directly)

2. Master Table: Pronominal Adverb Compounds (Da(r)- & Wo(r)-)

German forbids preposition + pronoun for inanimate objects (e.g. **für es* is wrong!). Instead, use **da-** (demonstrative) or **wo-** (interrogative/relative) compounds.

Base Preposition	DA(R)- Compound (Statement / Reference)	WO(R)- Compound (Question / Clause)
für (for)	dafür (for that / in favor of it) <i>Ich bin absolut dafür!</i>	wofür (for what? / what for?) <i>Wofür interessierst du dich?</i>
mit (with)	damit (with that / with it) <i>Was machst du damit?</i>	womit (with what? / wherewith?) <i>Womit fährst du zur Arbeit?</i>
über (about / over)	darüber (about that / over it) <i>Wir sprechen morgen darüber.</i>	worüber (about what?) <i>Worüber lachst du?</i>
an (at / on / about)	daran / dran (about it / on it) <i>Ich denke oft daran.</i>	woran (about what? / on what?) <i>Woran denkst du gerade?</i>
auf (on / upon)	darauf / drauf (on that / forward to it) <i>Ich freue mich darauf!</i>	worauf (on what? / for what?) <i>Worauf wartest du?</i>
von (from / of)	davon (from it / of that) <i>Ich habe nichts davon gewusst.</i>	wovon (from what? / of what?) <i>Wovon träumst du nachts?</i>
zu (to / for)	dazu (to that / in addition) <i>Was sagst du dazu?</i>	wozu (to what end? / why?) <i>Wozu brauchen wir das?</i>
in (in / into)	darin / drin (inside that / in it) <i>Darin liegt das Geheimnis.</i>	worin (in what? / wherein?) <i>Worin besteht das Problem?</i>
nach (after / for)	danach (after that / according to it) <i>Danach gehen wir essen.</i>	wonach (after what? / for what?) <i>Wonach suchst du?</i>
vor (before / of)	davor (in front of that / before it) <i>Ich habe Angst davor.</i>	wovor (of what? / before what?) <i>Wovor fürchtest du dich?</i>

3. Directional & Spatial Prefixes (Richtungspartikeln)

Adverbial particles combine to construct precise spatial relations.

Affix Partikel	Spatial Meaning	Examples
hin- / her-	Vector: hin (away from observer →) vs. her (towards observer ←)	<i>hinauf / herauf, hinein / herein, hinüber / herüber</i>
rings-	Circular spatial perimeter / enclosure ('all around')	<i>ringsum, ringsherum, ringsumher</i> (all around / surrounding)
über-	Temporal/spatial exceedance or carryover	<i>übermorgen</i> (day after tomorrow), <i>überall</i> (everywhere)
un-	Negation or intense temporal recency	<i>unlängst</i> (recently / not long ago), <i>ungemein</i> (immensely / uncommonly)